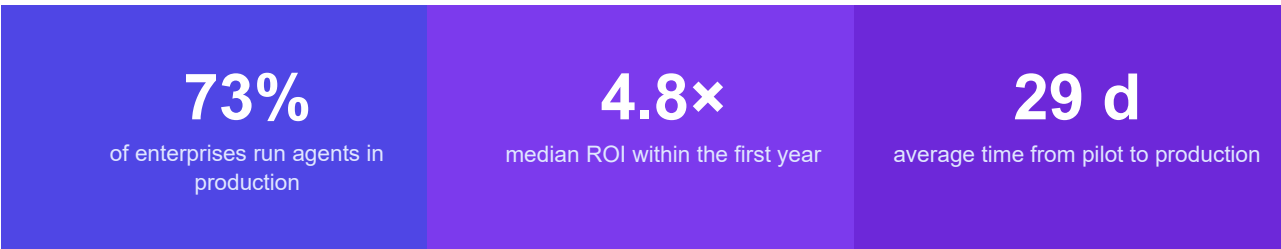


State of Agent Operations 2026

Executive brief — Northlight Research Group

Key Findings

Our third annual survey covers 412 organizations operating autonomous agents across customer operations, engineering, and finance. Three numbers define the year:



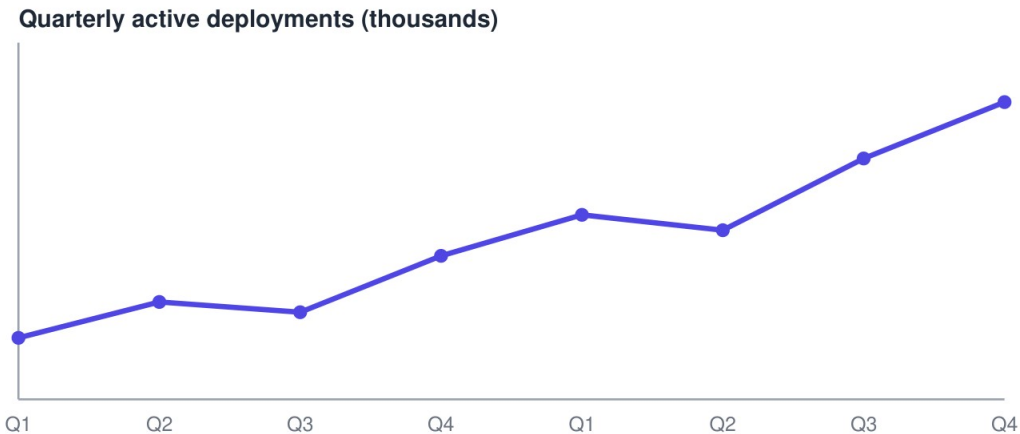
The gap between leaders and laggards is widening. Leaders standardize evaluation harnesses and treat prompts as versioned artifacts; laggards still ship prompt changes without regression coverage.

"The bottleneck moved from model quality to operational discipline in a single budget cycle."

— VP Platform Engineering, Fortune 100 retailer

Deployment Trajectory

Active deployments doubled in the trailing twelve months, with growth concentrated in mid-market adopters:



What Leaders Do Differently

- Budget for evaluation infrastructure before scaling headcount.
- Route by task value: premium models for revenue paths only.
- Keep humans on exception queues, not approval queues.

Full methodology and cohort definitions: northlight.example.org/agents-2026.